

Comprehensive Plan for the CASSI (Community Assistance and Social Services Impact) Loan Forgiveness Program

1. Program Overview

The **CASSI Loan Forgiveness Program** is an initiative designed to address workforce shortages in social services, mental health care, substance abuse counseling, nonprofit management, and prevention work in Ohio's historically underserved counties. The program offers student loan forgiveness to incentivize professionals to commit to working full-time in these areas for up to 10 years, thereby helping build sustainable community support systems. This financial relief will enable qualified professionals to alleviate their student debt while serving in roles critical to community well-being, mental health, and addiction prevention.

2. Program Goals

The **CASSI Loan Forgiveness Program** aims to:

- **Strengthen Social Services:** Fill critical workforce gaps in Ohio's most underserved areas by encouraging professionals to work in social services, mental health, addiction counseling, and nonprofit leadership roles.
 - **Combat Addiction and Mental Health Crises:** Respond to the opioid epidemic and other substance abuse crises by supporting addiction recovery professionals and mental health workers in high-need areas.
 - **Build Nonprofit Leadership Capacity:** Enable nonprofit leaders to manage organizations that serve vulnerable populations, helping to create more effective social safety nets in underserved areas.
 - **Promote Prevention Efforts:** Include prevention workers such as **Ohio Certified Prevention Specialists (OCPS)** and **Ohio Certified Prevention Consultants (OCPC)** to help address substance abuse and mental health challenges before they escalate.
 - **Reduce Student Debt Burden:** Provide up to **\$50,000 in loan forgiveness** over 10 years to professionals working full-time in qualifying roles, thereby alleviating financial barriers to entering and staying in critical professions.
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3. Loan Forgiveness Structure

A. Loan Forgiveness Breakdown

- **Annual Loan Forgiveness:** Participants will receive **10% loan forgiveness** per year of full-time qualifying work.
- **Forgiveness Cap:**
 - A **\$50,000 cap** for loan forgiveness for participants with a **Bachelor's degree**.
 - Total forgiveness will be capped at \$50,000 for the entire duration of the program (10 years).

B. Eligible Loans

- **Federal Student Loans:** The program will cover the following types of loans:
 - **Direct Loans** (subsidized and unsubsidized).
 - **Direct PLUS Loans** (for graduate students, if applicable).
 - **Federal Perkins Loans** (if held by the participant).

C. Stacking of Loan Caps

- Initially, the program focuses on a **Bachelor's degree loan forgiveness cap of \$50,000**. If expanded in the future to include **Master's degrees**, the total cap for all degrees combined would remain at **\$75,000**.

D. Rolling 365-Day Certification

- Loan forgiveness will be applied annually based on **365 days** of full-time employment in a qualifying role. Each year of employment will result in **10% loan forgiveness**, provided participants remain in a qualifying position and location.

4. Eligible Professions and Certifications

A. Eligible Professions

The CASSI Loan Forgiveness Program is designed to cover a range of high-need professions. Participants can work in any qualifying employment setting, and all qualifying certifications or degrees will allow flexibility in where they can serve.

1. Social Workers

- **Eligible Licenses:**
 - Licensed Social Worker (LSW).
 - Licensed Independent Social Worker (LISW).
 - Licensed Clinical Social Worker (LCSW).
- **Key Roles:**
 - Providing mental health counseling, addiction recovery services, and family support.

2. Mental Health Counselors

- **Eligible Licenses:**
 - Licensed Professional Counselor (LPC).
 - Licensed Professional Clinical Counselor (LPCC).
- **Key Roles:**
 - Offering counseling for mental health and addiction recovery, particularly in crisis intervention settings.

3. Substance Abuse Counselors

- **Eligible Licenses:**
 - Licensed Chemical Dependency Counselor (LCDC).
 - Certified Alcohol and Drug Counselor (CADC).
- **Key Roles:**
 - Delivering substance abuse prevention, addiction recovery support, and harm reduction services.

4. Nonprofit Management Professionals

- **Eligible Degrees/Certifications:**
 - Certified Nonprofit Professional (CNP).
 - Degrees in Nonprofit Management or Public Administration.
- **Key Roles:**
 - Leading nonprofit organizations that focus on public health, housing, addiction recovery, child welfare, and community outreach.

5. Prevention Workers

- **Eligible Certifications:**
 - Ohio Certified Prevention Specialist (OCPS).
 - Ohio Certified Prevention Consultant (OCPC).
- **Key Roles:**
 - Leading substance abuse prevention and mental health promotion efforts in schools, nonprofits, and public health departments.

B. Flexibility Across Employment Settings

- All qualifying degrees and certifications are eligible for employment in **any** of the qualifying settings, ensuring flexibility for participants. For example, a **Licensed Chemical Dependency Counselor (LCDC)** can work in a **crisis service provider** setting, even if it is not strictly an addiction recovery center.

5. Eligible Employment Settings

Participants in the CASSI Loan Forgiveness Program must work in one of the following qualifying settings:

- **Community Mental Health Centers:** Providing comprehensive mental health services to low-income populations.
 - **Public Health Departments:** Offering addiction recovery and mental health prevention initiatives.
 - **Substance Abuse Treatment Centers:** Helping individuals recover from addiction, with a focus on underserved populations.
 - **Nonprofits:** Organizations providing critical services in housing, mental health, addiction recovery, and social services.
 - **Schools:** Focused on delivering mental health services and substance abuse prevention to students in low-income or high-risk areas.
 - **MRSS (Mobile Response and Stabilization Services):** Added to support crisis services for individuals and families experiencing acute mental health or behavioral health crises.
 - **Youth and Family Services Organizations:** Providing child welfare services, youth outreach, and family stabilization programs.
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6. Eligible Counties

To ensure that the CASSI Loan Forgiveness Program targets Ohio's most underserved communities, the following counties are identified for the program's initial launch:

- **Scioto County**
- **Vinton County**
- **Meigs County**
- **Lawrence County**
- **Gallia County**
- **Jackson County**
- **Pike County**
- **Ross County**
- **Adams County**
- **Monroe County**

These counties face some of the highest rates of poverty, substance abuse, and mental health challenges in the state, making them ideal candidates for the program.

7. Application Process

A. Initial Application

The application process will be managed through an online portal. Applicants will need to provide:

1. **Personal Information:**
 - Name, contact information, and Social Security number (for loan matching purposes).
2. **Employment Information:**
 - Employer's name and location.
 - Job title, start date, and verification of full-time status.
3. **Degree and Licensure Information:**
 - Proof of licensure or certification (e.g., LSW, OCPS).
 - Documentation of the degree(s) earned.
4. **Loan Information:**
 - Federal loan types and amounts.
 - Most recent loan statements from loan servicers.

B. Supporting Documents

- **Employment Verification:** A signed verification form from the employer confirming that the participant is employed full-time in a qualifying role.
- **Licensure and Degree Verification:** Copies of licenses, certifications, and diplomas.
- **Loan Documentation:** Official loan statements to verify loan amounts and eligibility.

C. Annual Certification

Participants must recertify every 365 days by submitting updated employment verification and loan status documentation. The annual certification process ensures that participants continue to meet the program's eligibility criteria.

D. Appeals Process

Participants can appeal denied applications or certifications through a formal dispute process. Appeals will be reviewed by program administrators, who will recheck eligibility and resolve disputes.

8. Funding Model

A. Primary Funding Source: Tax on Recreational Marijuana Sales

The CASSI Loan Forgiveness Program will be primarily funded through revenue generated from the taxation of recreational marijuana sales. Based on other states' experiences, Ohio could generate significant revenue from marijuana sales, with a portion allocated to fund CASSI.

- **Revenue Projections:** States like Colorado and Illinois generate hundreds of millions of dollars annually from marijuana taxes. Ohio could generate similar revenue, with **\$30 million to \$45 million** earmarked for CASSI from recreational marijuana sales.

B. Additional Funding Sources

To supplement marijuana tax revenue, other funding sources may include:

- **State Budget Allocations:** To address shortfalls or revenue fluctuations.
 - **Federal Grants:** Securing federal grants focused on workforce development, mental health, and substance abuse prevention.
 - **Private and Philanthropic Partnerships:** Collaborations with nonprofit organizations and private foundations to provide additional financial support.
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9. Sustainability and Growth

A. Legislative Support and Oversight

- Ongoing legislative support is essential for ensuring that a portion of marijuana tax revenue is allocated to CASSI. Legislative action will also support future program expansions, such as increasing the cap for Master's degrees.

B. Program Audits and Accountability

Annual audits will ensure the program remains fiscally sustainable and meets its goals. Financial oversight will help maintain transparency, with detailed reports submitted to stakeholders and the legislature.

C. Contingency Planning

- An **emergency reserve fund** will be established to cover potential shortfalls in tax revenue.
 - **Participant Limits:** In case of budget constraints, participant limits may be implemented to control program costs while maintaining commitments to current participants.
 - **Forgiveness Adjustments:** The forgiveness rate (currently 10% per year) could be temporarily adjusted if funding is insufficient.
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Conclusion

The **CASSI Loan Forgiveness Program** represents a targeted solution to Ohio's workforce challenges in underserved counties, offering significant loan forgiveness to social workers, mental health counselors, substance abuse professionals, nonprofit leaders, and prevention

specialists. By funding the program through recreational marijuana taxes and providing flexible work settings, CASSI offers a sustainable and effective approach to supporting Ohio's most vulnerable communities.